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**Phallic Myth and Sexual Rapport Reprogrammed: Lacanian
Analysis of Bryan Forbes' Film *The Stepford Wives* (1975)**

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Phallic Myth and Sexual Rapport Reprogrammed: Lacanian Analysis of Bryan Forbes' Film *The Stepford Wives* (1975)

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Abstract

The aim of this paper is to analyse Bryan Forbes' 1975 psychological thriller "The Stepford Wives", adaptation of Ira Levin's 1972 novel of the same name, in the light of French psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan's psychoanalytic theory of "Phallic myth" and "Sexual non-rapport". The paper explores how the male characters in the film reinstate the fiction of masculinity and through this, attempt to build a harmonious relationship (devoid of potential threat to their masculine superiority) with their wives by killing and replacing them with robots, thus moulding them into idealised version of "The woman". The first part of this study elaborates on Lacanian concepts of "Phallic myth", "Truth of femininity", "Sexual non-rapport". The relation between truth and fiction has been explained and elaborated through another film "The Vantage Point". Then it is also discussed how Lacan associates the concept of fiction or myth with masculinity (Phallic myth) and truth with femininity (Truth of femininity). The second and third part analyse the film through those Lacanian concepts. This paper contributes to the existing link between film studies, gender studies and Lacanian psychoanalysis.

Keywords: Lacanian psychoanalysis, Film, Phallic myth, Femininity, Sexual non-rapport.

1. Introduction

The Stepford Wives (1975), adapted from Ira Levin's novel, explores a dystopian suburban reality where women are transformed into compliant, submissive spouses, stripped of their individuality to fulfil an idealized, male-dominated vision of femininity. This unsettling transformation seems to hit upon Jacques Lacan's psychoanalytic notions of the "Phallic myth" and "Sexual non-rapport". By examining Lacan's insights on masculinity as a constructed authority and the unknowable and elusive nature of femininity, "The Stepford Wives" reveals a disturbing response to the inevitable lack of "sexual rapport" between men and women. In this film, the men of Stepford seek to assert absolute control by replacing their wives with "perfect" robotic doubles who mirror their desires and reinforce their fragile masculinity. Through this lens, the film explores the patriarchal fantasy of dominance, portraying it as a desperate escape from genuine intimacy and mutual respect. In this article, Lacan's theories illuminate how the film dissects the psychological underpinnings of masculine insecurity and the emptiness of the desire for control. By reducing women to symbols of male authority and eliminating their autonomy, the men of Stepford construct an artificial reality in order to authenticate the myth of masculinity and eradicate the impossibility of rapport in man-woman relationships.

2. Phallic Myth and Sexual Non-Rapport

In Jacques Lacan's psychoanalytic framework, the Imaginary, Symbolic, and the Real

(RSI) – the three registers unfold the complexities of human subjectivity. The Imaginary is the world of images. The child does not possess a sense of the self until the “mirror stage” which marks the formation of the ego through self-recognition in the mirror, while the Symbolic encompasses the realm of language, law, prohibitions. The Real, beyond linguistic representation, encompasses experiences of trauma and death. In Lacanian psychoanalysis, the concept of fiction/truth is a critical concern touching upon how we construct, perceive, and ultimately experience reality. This relation can be illustrated through Pete Travis’ 2008 film *The Vantage Point*. The film portrays an assassination attempt on the US president in Spain. This incident has been reenacted from multiple perspectives. Although these narratives strive to uncover the truth about the incident, the primordial or original scene of assassination has already been lost. The truth of the incident is revealed only through human interpretations and constructs. This demonstrates that truth possesses the structure of fiction. Truth is a symbolic structure which also touches the real which lies beyond any form of linguistic representation. Lacan would suggest that this pursuit of truth through the narration of events underscores that truth is inseparable from the language used to articulate it. Truth, in this sense, does not exist as an independent reality; it can only be accessed through the symbolic narrative, the language and structure we impose upon it. Lacan explored this in depth in “The Seminar on ‘The Purloined Letter’”, where he proposed that truth possesses a fictional structure. In his view, fiction occupies the domain of the symbolic—the sphere where language, social norms, and shared meanings operate. Truth, by contrast, cannot be fully articulated within this symbolic framework, as it is elusive and always partly unsaid. This ‘unsaid’ dimension of truth corresponds to what Lacan calls the Real – a

domain that exists beyond language and symbolization, remaining resistant to direct representation.

Lacan further develops this notion by linking masculinity with fiction and femininity with truth. For him, femininity, in its purest and most authentic sense, resides outside the confines of the Symbolic order or phallogentric language. It transcends language, eluding comprehension and articulation. Thus, femininity aligns with the Real, that aspect of experience that cannot be fully captured or represented in words. In contrast, masculinity is associated with the concept of the “phallic myth” which arises from the notion of the phallus. In Lacanian thought, the phallus is not the biological organ but a symbolic signifier representing power, dominance, and the construction of male identity. This phallic symbol gives rise to the myth of masculinity which is rooted in authority, virility, and a sense of superiority. A purely authentic woman would be utterly incomprehensible to herself and others, standing as a profound challenge to the patriarchal structure, which relies on language and symbolic constructs to establish and maintain order. She would oscillate between the Symbolic (authenticating masculine superiority / “phallic myth”) and the Real (posing potential threat to the fictional structure of masculinity and thus embodying an experience beyond language’s reach). Therefore, the idea of ‘woman’ as we understand it is, according to Lacan, a patriarchal construct. This is why he famously stated, “There is no such thing as woman”. What we recognize as femininity within the symbolic order is, in reality, a projection, a fiction imposed upon what inherently surpasses linguistic and symbolic representation. Thus, truth, femininity, and the Real each elude full articulation, leaving us with narratives that strive toward but can never fully capture the essence of these concepts.

Woman functions as a symptom of man. This relationship implies that woman, within the masculine psyche, does not enter as a full, independent subject but rather as a fantasy object— an entity shaped and defined by male desire. As a symptom, woman represents the disguised fulfillment of man's repressed sexual desires, particularly those stemming from the earliest, forbidden impulses directed toward the mother. In the psyche of the masculine subject, this original desire had to be repressed due to the paternal prohibition, creating a gap where the primordial object of desire— the mother— is lost. Consequently, woman emerges as a substitute object of desire, a stand-in for this unreachable maternal figure. For the masculine subject, woman thus functions as a substitute that fills this void left by the lost primordial object. The desire directed towards her is a response to the absence and impossibility of the original, maternal connection. As a result, man's relationship with woman is not a direct or fully genuine connection but a symptomatic one, marked by an unresolved tension. Woman, in this role, serves to validate and authenticate the fiction of masculinity, reinforcing the image of male authority, virility, and superiority. Yet at the same time, woman as she exists in her own right—qua woman—remains foreign to the masculine psyche. This dimension of woman, wholly outside male experience and understanding, exists in the realm of the Other, beyond the reach of language and symbolization. This positioning of woman as Other, outside the masculine language and understanding, reveals her as a potential threat to the very constructs on which male identity is built. Since a woman in her true form cannot be fully comprehended or controlled, she challenges the masculine illusions of power and superiority. Thus, the man-woman relationship becomes one of inherent tension and inauthenticity. Since woman as a symptom merely supports the fiction of masculinity,

and since man's connection to her is ultimately a displaced or symptomatic relationship, their union is based on a fundamental lie. Because of this, Lacan famously asserted that there can be no true "sexual rapport" between man and woman. The phrase reflects his view that the relationship between the sexes is inherently asymmetrical, unable to achieve a true, reciprocal connection. Instead, the relationship is constructed through a series of displacements, projections, and symptoms, with women occupying a space that is at once essential to the male psyche yet impossible for it to fully grasp or integrate. This lack of sexual rapport emphasizes the distance between male and female desire, and the ways in which language, fantasy and repression shape their interactions, leaving the relationship perpetually unfulfilled.

3. Phallic Myth and the Creation of "Perfect" Woman

As we have discussed, Lacan's concept of the phallic myth centers on the symbolic authority that masculinity holds in shaping social and psychological structures. This myth represents a fantasy of power and wholeness that men attempt to attain but always fall short of fully achieving. Masculinity, in this framework, is haunted by the impossibility of absolute authority, which leads to anxieties about inadequacy and loss of control. In "The Stepford Wives", the men seek to eliminate this anxiety by literalizing their authority over women. They construct wives that embody their ideals without the complexity or unpredictability of real human personalities. The husband's conspiracy is exposed in scenes like Joanna's realization that Bobbie, her once self-assured and vibrant friend, has undergone an opposing transformation. When Joanna visits Bobbie after her change, she finds her cooking obsessively and behaving submissively—a stark contrast to the witty, self-assured woman she knew. Similarly, Charmaine's transformation after her

weekend trip epitomizes the phallic myth's demand for absolute female submission. Initially independent and spirited, she returns home suddenly devoted, having fired her maid and destroyed her beloved tennis court. Her radical shift highlights how Stepford's men reshape their wives to embody an idealized, compliant femininity that mirrors male desires. By erasing her individuality and passions, Charmaine becomes a mere reflection of her husband's authority. Here, the film visually embodies the phallic myth: each wife becomes an icon of male desire, crafted to ensure the men's authority remains unchallenged. This "perfected" femininity provides the men with a symbol of power that reflects back their own desire for dominance, silencing the natural friction and individuality that would otherwise destabilize their control.

Walter attends the Men's Association, a secretive group of Stepford men, which turns out to be responsible for transforming their wives into submissive robots. The association exemplifies the phallic myth in action: a male-dominated structure where men assert ultimate authority over women's identities, thus reducing them to objects of male fantasy. Lacan's concept of the big Other is also at play here, as the Men's Association functions as an embodiment of patriarchal law—a societal structure that dictates norms, values, and roles.

Another of the film's most telling scenes occurs when Joanna and her friend Bobbie barge into Carol Van Sant's home. They overhear Carol during an intimate moment with her husband. She repeatedly exclaims phrases like, "You're the best," "You're the champion," "You're the king," and "You're the master." This incessant mechanical praise underscores how Carol's new identity is engineered solely to reinforce her husband's ego that is endlessly feeding his need for validation and superiority. Her

robotic repetition of these phrases transforms what should be a natural and mutual interaction into a scripted performance designed to authenticate her husband's sense of masculine power and superiority.

This scene is crucial because it reveals the extent to which the Stepford men seek to turn their wives into extensions of their own self-image. Carol's exaggerated affirmations function to soothe any male insecurities by providing a constant echo of superiority. Here masculinity is not an innate quality but something constructed, dependent on an external, submissive figure to mirror back the power and mastery that these men desire. Carol's programming erases any individuality, molding her into a reflection of her husband's fantasies. By creating these artificial wives, the men of Stepford literally enact the phallic myth. They craft an environment where their authority is absolutely unaffected by the unpredictability or resistance of real human relationships.

The psychological function of those scenes also reflects the fragility of this constructed masculinity. The men's need for programmed wives who continually affirm their dominance reveals an underlying insecurity and dependency on patriarchal structure. This "perfect" woman is an idealized, malleable figure whose entire existence revolves around maintaining and securing male power. The illusion of the phallic myth is thus preserved through the literal erasure of female autonomy. The Stepford men avoid confronting the complexities of mutual relationships by imposing a mechanical, rigid structure that validates them at every turn.

4. Sexual Rapport *vis-à-vis* Artificial Reality

Lacan's concept of sexual non-rapport holds that complete harmony or connection

between the sexes is an impossibility due to their fundamentally different relationships with desire and the symbolic order. This lack of rapport becomes the source of marital dissatisfaction among the men of Stepford, who are frustrated by their wives' autonomy and assertiveness. In response, they design "robot wives" to achieve an idealized relationship where women are completely subservient, aligning with their male-centric needs.

Joanna begins noticing the eerie sameness in Stepford women, who appear overly submissive, shallow, and entirely focused on domestic duties. In Lacanian terms, these women represent a distorted response to sexual non-rapport—the impossibility of a true, reciprocal relationship between man and woman. Rather than engaging with women as complex individuals with desires of their own, Stepford husbands have eliminated the threat of non-rapport by creating robotic wives, who, in their uniformity, avoid any disruption of male dominance. Here, the wives are reduced to mere symptoms of male desire, mirroring Lacan's idea of woman as object within the male psyche's symbolic economy.

Claude's personal project of recording the voices of the women in Stepford under the guise of a casual hobby or a tool for law enforcement masks a far darker intention. He is creating a database of each woman's voice so that their robotic replacements will sound like them, mimicking a familiar trait but devoid of genuine personality or agency. This act of recording illustrates how the men's desire isn't for their partners in their entirety, but rather for select parts that align with their constructed fantasies. By focusing on capturing only the voice, an isolated trait, the Stepford men reveal their desire for a fragmented version of femininity—one stripped of complexity, unpredictability and

independence. To evoke Lacanian insight in this context, this reflects the notion of “objet petit a” or the part object, which represents the specific aspects of the other that evoke desire. Instead of embracing their wives’ complete identities, the men fixate on elements like voice, appearance or demeanour that can be controlled and perfected to suit their patriarchal ideals. This fragmented desire underscores the reduction of these women to mere objects, each defined by isolated traits that can be replicated and manipulated. Through Claude’s project, *The Stepford Wives* critiques the men’s inability to desire or accept their partners as whole beings, choosing instead to strip away individuality to construct an artificial “perfect” woman from preferred parts—a troubling illusion of companionship that sidesteps the complexities of genuine human connection.

Joanna confronts Bobbie, who has been transformed into a robot, devoid of her prior personality. Joanna’s horror at discovering Bobbie’s mechanical, lifeless form is an encounter with the Real, as Lacan would define it—the absolute limit of her understanding, where language fails, and the horror of male control becomes undeniable. This scene powerfully illustrates the lengths to which the men of Stepford go to eliminate the possibility of sexual non-rapport by creating women who do not deviate from male expectations.

This theme reaches a climax when Joanna confronts her fate at the Men’s Association, realizing her husband and his peers plan to replace her with an emotionless double. The Stepford husbands’ vision of rapport is one-sided, achievable only by silencing real women’s voices. By turning their wives into mere reflections of male desire, they believe they can eliminate the challenges and anxieties of non-rapport—yet these relationships are ultimately hollow and lifeless, dependent on the suppression of

female subjectivity.

The final scene shows Joanna, now transformed, pushing a shopping cart in Stepford's supermarket alongside the other robotic wives. This scene reinforces the total erasure of her individuality – a chilling image of how the phallic order in Stepford has achieved complete control. By eliminating any space for sexual non-rapport, the men of Stepford have created a world devoid of authentic connection. Women, reduced to symbols of male desire, are incapable of expressing any form of independent agency or desire.

5. Conclusion

The Stepford Wives reveals a disturbing fantasy of masculine control over femininity where real women are sacrificed to preserve an idealized masculine authority. Through Lacan's concepts of the "phallic myth" and "sexual non-rapport", the film analyses the inherent insecurities in this attempt to maintain control. Each Stepford husband's need for a robot wife underscores his fear of genuine connection which would require vulnerability and mutual respect. By reprogramming women to meet their needs, the men believe they can finally possess the perfect "rapport," yet they create only an illusion of harmony. The film exposes the fragility of traditional masculinity, which is portrayed as desperate to avoid any authentic encounter with the other. The Stepford husbands' pursuit of control would ultimately leave them isolated in a world of their own construction, suggesting that attempts to evade non-rapport by force would result in a lifeless, hollow reality devoid of true intimacy.

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